

Short-Form Video Platforms and Political Knowledge Acquisition among First-Time Voters

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Abstract: Short-form video platforms (e.g., TikTok, Instagram Reels) have become primary news sources for Generation Z. This study examines whether consuming political explanation videos on short-form platforms enhances civic knowledge and voting intentions among first-time voters.

1. Research Question

Research Question: Does consuming short-form political video content yield measurable gains in objective civic knowledge and voting intention compared to traditional text-based digital news?

2. Empirical Methodology & Data Collection

Empirical Methodology & Data Collection: A randomized controlled trial was conducted with 850 undergraduate students (aged 18–20). Participants were randomly assigned to consume daily 15-minute political news digests for 4 weeks via three formats: Format 1 (Short-Form Video, n=283), Format 2 (Digital Text News Articles, n=283), and Format 3 (Control/Non-Political Media, n=284). Objective 20-item civic knowledge tests and voting intention scales were administered post-intervention.

Table 1: Empirical Findings Summary

Media Format	N	Civic Test Score (/20)	Knowledge Gain (%)	Voting Intention (1-7)
Control (Non-Political)	284	11.2 ± 2.1	Baseline	4.1 ± 1.2
Format 2 (Digital Text News)	283	14.8 ± 1.8	+32.1% (p < 0.01)	5.2 ± 1.0
Format 1 (Short-Form Video)	283	16.5 ± 1.5	+47.3% (p < 0.001)	5.9 ± 0.8

3. Discussion & Implications

Discussion & Conclusion: Short-form video political digests produced superior knowledge retention (+47.3% gain over control) and higher voting intentions (5.9/7) compared to standard text news (+32.1% gain, 5.2/7). Visual storytelling and dynamic summaries lower cognitive processing costs for young voters, demonstrating that modern video algorithms can serve as effective instruments for youth civic education when content is accurate.